

ing and the dithering of other parties like the NCP, whose Deputy Chief Minister R.R. Patil holds the Home portfolio, Raj got more mileage in a week than he'd got in all the years since his bitter parting with his fire-breathing uncle. Even as NCP chief Sharad Pawar publicly ridiculed the childish antics of Raj, the MNS chief managed to stir the national parties out of their comfort zones to act against him, which the Sena believes will work to his advantage.

The week-long drama has brought to the fore the divide between the national and regional parties. While

Political experts observe that the state leaders have chosen to remain mum fearing the ire of the local Marathi voters. The Shiv Sena, which recently jumped into the fray by pledging support for the Marathi *manoos*, dismisses Raj's arrest. "Such inquiries and actions are a routine part of a politician's life," says Shiv Sena MP Sanjay Raut. Rumours are rife that Bal Thackeray, his son Uddhav and some leaders of the NCP tried to convince Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh to prevent the arrests, fearing a rise in Raj's popularity.

Popularity is what both Raj and

took rationality in Mumbai and parts of the state. While shopkeepers shut shop, office-goers rushed home and taxis and autos went off roads in Mumbai and north Indians in other parts of the state boarded trains in large numbers to return to their home town. MNS and SP workers clashed for the second consecutive week, stoning BEST buses and throwing the city out of gear for a few hours. The police registered over 470 cases of arson, damage to property and assault and made "preventive arrests".

Sporadic violence erupted across various cities and towns of



senior BJP leader L.K. Advani strongly criticised the Thackeray cousins for statements that were "unconstitutional and against national integration", Pawar merely dismissed them as "irresponsible". The Maharashtra Government was also divided over Raj's arrest. While some believed that his arrest would make him a hero, others like Congress Mumbai President Gurudas Kamat had pressurised the Government to take strict action. "The Shiv Sena adopted the same approach years ago and now we have to deal with them as a political party. If we ignore Raj, people will start taking law into their hands," says Kamat.

ACTION AND INACTION: Rioting mobs; NCP's Pawar and Patil

Azmi's SP desperately needed to get out of their political wilderness. The SP, seen as an emerging force in the state politics in just five years, has lost its potent force. And Raj, who started the MNS with much fanfare after an acrimonious succession battle in the Shiv Sena, began with a bang but was reduced to a whimper within two years. No wonder then that Mumbai was agog with rumours that the Raj-Azmi verbal skirmishes were a ploy to get out of political exile.

As news of Raj's arrest and a backlash spread, the fear factor over-

Maharashtra as well. Mobsters stoned and smashed public transport buses in Pune's Pimpri-Chinchwad area and forcibly shut shops. In Nashik, MNS workers stormed into north Indian localities, forcing people to leave. Terrified migrants swarmed railway stations to get away from mobs, forcing Deshmukh to appeal that "there is no need to flee Maharashtra" and that he had directed the police to "take the strictest action possible".

But the protests against the Government inaction are not limited to opposition politicians. Even Kamat says, "The police are fully authorised to arrest offenders. Why are they waiting for the Government's approval and going soft on Raj?" The answer to that question must come from the state Government that his own party runs from India's commercial capital. ■

By merely ridiculing Raj and not calling for his arrest, Pawar played safe and did not hurt local sentiments.